

Gobryas without general resistance on the sixteenth day of the month Tishri. It was after this event that Nabonidus was captured.⁵⁷⁴ Cyrus entered the city a little over two weeks later. If there is any harmony at all between the cuneiform record, the account of Xenophon, and the statement found in the fifth chapter of Daniel, Belshazzar must have been slain at the time Gobryas took possession of Babylon. This being the case, it is not hard to believe that 'the wife of the king,' Belshazzar's mother, died after the entrance of Cyrus into Babylon. Grief on account of the death of her son and the passing of Babylon into foreign hands may have hastened the death of Nabonidus' queen. Like him she was probably advanced in years.⁵⁷⁵ If, as has been shown,⁵⁷⁶ the wife of Nabonidus was Nitocris and if the probability that she was a daughter of Nebuchadrezzar⁵⁷⁷ is taken into account, the lamentation which took place gains new significance. These are considerations which should not be overlooked in an endeavor to determine the original meaning of the *Nabonidus Chronicle*.

2. Data Furnished by the Cyrus Cylinder

Another cuneiform document dealing in a general way with the close of Nabonidus' reign and the establishment of Persian rule in Babylonia is known as the *Cyrus Cylinder*. This is not a circumstantial narrative of events. The text is confined to an exaltation of Cyrus' rôle as champion of the rights of the Babylonian people. The first part of the record is in a very fragmentary condition.⁵⁷⁸ It is possible to determine, however, from the portions of lines which remain that the aim of the chronicler was to make a strong case in favor of Persian intervention in the affairs of Babylonia. The inhabitants of the land are represented as suffering under the tyranny of an impious oppressor, so much so that Marduk, their supreme god, is moved to pity. This induces the deity to select a leader who will save the people from the consequences of their deplorable condition.

⁵⁷⁴ There is no reference to the death of Nabonidus. Berossus states that Cyrus gave Nabonidus Carmania as a place in which he could spend the rest of his life. See Josephus, *Contra Apionem* I, 20.

⁵⁷⁵ See p. 32f.

⁵⁷⁶ See pp. 38ff.

⁵⁷⁷ See pp. 51-63.

⁵⁷⁸ KA p. 2f, line 1-10.